

# ERIC MARTIN FELTHAM

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Last updated: August 2026

## EMPLOYMENT

### Data Science Institute Postdoctoral Fellow

Columbia University

Sept. 2024–Present

New York, NY

### Postdoctoral Associate

Yale Institute for Network Science and Department of Sociology,  
Yale University

June 2023–Aug. 2024

New Haven, CT

## EDUCATION

### Ph.D., Sociology (with Distinction), Yale University

Dissertation: “Cognizing Social Networks”

Committee: Drs. Nicholas Christakis (chair), Emily Erikson, Laura Forastiere,  
Ifat Levy

Winner of the 2024 Marvin B. Sussman Dissertation Prize from  
Yale University

May 2023

New Haven, CT

### M.A., Statistics, Yale University

2018

New Haven, CT

### B.A., Philosophy; B.A., Economics, University of Massachusetts Amherst

*magna cum laude*, Phi Beta Kappa

2013

Amherst, MA

## RESEARCH INTERESTS

Social network cognition: how people map social structure, who they believe is tied to whom, and what these representations mean for influence, diffusion, and collective action in groups and organizations. Related interests: social theory; intergroup boundaries, coordination, and conflict. Methods: computational social science, causal inference, and experiments.

## PUBLICATIONS

### PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

**Eric Feltham**, Laura Forastiere, and Nicholas Christakis. “Cognitive representations of social networks in isolated villages”. *Nature Human Behaviour* 9, 1737–1753 (2025). <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-025-02221-6>

- Selected for a “Research Briefing” feature by *Nature Human Behaviour*. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-025-02222-5>
- Featured in Phys.org (“Biases shape how people mentally represent social ties in their community, study suggests”, June 2025)

**Eric Feltham**, Laura Forastiere, Marcus Alexander, Nicholas Christakis. “Mass gatherings for political expression had no discernible association with the local course of the COVID-19 pandemic in the USA in 2020 and 2021”. *Nature Human Behaviour* 7, 1708–1728 (2023). <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-023-01654-1>

- Featured in *FiveThirtyEight*.

Philipp Homan, Ifat Levy, **Eric Feltham**, Charles Gordon, Jingchu Hu, Jian Li, Robert H. Pietrzak, Steven Southwick, John H. Krystal, Ilan Harpaz-Rotem, Daniela Schiller. “Neural computations of threat in the aftermath of combat trauma”. *Nature Neuroscience* 22, 470–476 (2019). <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41593-018-0315-x>

## BOOK CHAPTERS

Emily Erikson and **Eric Feltham**. “Structure”. In *Research Handbook on Analytical Sociology*. Cheltenham, UK: Edward Elgar Publishing (2021).

Emily Erikson and **Eric Feltham**. “Historical Network Research”. In *Oxford Handbook of Social Networks*. New York: Oxford UP (2020). <https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780190251765.001.0001>

## WORKING PAPERS

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Unpublished drafts are available at <https://emfeltham.github.io/working-papers/>

**Eric Feltham** and Nicholas Christakis. “Cognitive Expectations of Homophily in Village Social Networks”. Under review. SocArXiv preprint (2026). [https://osf.io/preprints/socarxiv/z4nyq\\_v3](https://osf.io/preprints/socarxiv/z4nyq_v3)

**Eric Feltham**. “Signal Degradation without Convergence: Scale Relevance and Partisan Boundary Investment”.

**Eric Feltham**. “The Decline in White Americans’ Implicit Racial Bias Diverged in 2016 Along the Geography of Manufacturing Decline”.

**Eric Feltham** and Nicholas Christakis. “Seeing Structure Similarly”.

**Eric Feltham**. “FormulaCompiler.jl and Margins.jl: Efficient Marginal Effects in Julia”. Under review. arXiv preprint (2026). <https://arxiv.org/abs/2601.07065>

**Eric Feltham**. “empirica-networks: online network experiments with Empirica”.

## RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

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**Eric Feltham**. “The Social and Cultural Context of Social Network Cognition”.

**Eric Feltham**, Laura Forastiere, Johan Ugander, and Nicholas Christakis. “Off-Policy Evaluation with Cognitive Social Structures”.

**Eric Feltham** and Nicholas Christakis. “The Networked Climate Game”.

**Eric Feltham**. “Off the Party Menu: Beliefs and Within-Party Hostility, 1972–2024”.

Dominik Duell, **Eric Feltham**, Nicholas Christakis. “Revolutions *in silico*”.

**Eric Feltham**. “TSCSMETHODS.jl: Extended Matching for Generalized Difference-in-Differences with Time-Series Cross-Sectional Data”.

## BOOK PROJECT

“Cognizing Social Networks” (working title). Manuscript in preparation; proposal under review.

## GRANTS

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|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <b>Research Grant (R01), “Characterizing Individuals’ Cognitive Maps of their Village Social Networks”</b> | <b>2022</b> |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|

National Institutes of Health, The National Institute on Aging and the Office of Behavioral and Social Sciences Research

- Lead author of the proposal, research design, and analysis plan. Award: \$3,226,809 over 4 years. PI: Dr. Nicholas Christakis.

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|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <b>“Assessing the Hazard of Elections During the COVID-19 Pandemic”</b> | <b>2020</b> |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|

Robert Wood Johnson Foundation

- Lead author of the proposal, research design, and analysis plan. Award: \$350,000. PI: Dr. Nicholas Christakis.

## HONORS AND AWARDS

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| <b>Sussman Prize for best dissertation in the past two years</b>     | <b>2024</b> |
| Yale Department of Sociology, New Haven, CT                          |             |
| <b>Commonwealth Honors College Scholar with Greatest Distinction</b> | <b>2013</b> |
| University of Massachusetts Amherst, Amherst, MA                     |             |

## INVITED TALKS

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### “Cognizing Social Networks”

- **Santa Fe Institute**, April 2026. Recording: <https://emfeltham.github.io/talks/>
- **Stanford Graduate School of Business**, Organizational Behavior Area, November 2025
- **Harvard University**, Department of Psychology (Cognition, Brain, Behavior Seminar), September 2025
- **Yale University**, Department of Sociology (Sussman Award Lecture), May 2025

### OTHER TALKS

- **Yale University**, Human Nature Lab — “Expecting Homophily”, January 2026
- **University of Iowa**, Department of Sociology (Social Networks Workshop) — “Cognizing Social Networks”, November 2023
- **Yale University**, Center for Empirical Research on Stratification and Inequality — “Modeling the Effect of Identity on Polarization”, January 2019
- **Yale Institute for Network Science** — “Experiments on Observational Learning”, August 2018

## CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

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### “Cognizing Social Networks”

- International Conference on Computational Social Science, Norrköping, Sweden, July 2025
- Annual Meeting of the American Sociological Association (Sections on Social Psychology and Mathematical Sociology), Montréal, QC, August 2024
- Duality@50: Making progress and looking forward, ETH Zürich, Ascona, Switzerland, April 2024
- Implementation and Dissemination Science Workshop, Copán, Honduras, June 2023

### “Expecting Homophily”

- Annual Meeting of the American Sociological Association (Sections on Social Psychology and Mathematical Sociology), New York City, August 2026
- International Conference on Computational Social Science, Burlington, VT, July 2026
- Annual Conference of the International Network for Social Network Analysis (Sunbelt 2026), Daytona Beach, FL, June 2026
- International Conference on Network Science (NetSci 2026), Boston, MA, June 2026
- Annual Conference of the International Network of Analytical Sociology, Columbia University, June 2025

Megha Chawla, Philipp Homan, Charles Gordon, **Eric Feltham**, Daniela Schiller, Ilan Harpaz-Rotem, Ifat Levy. “**Cortical thickness and volume of the right posterior parietal cortex predict individual learning rate in healthy adults**”

- Society for Neuroscience, San Diego, CA, 2018

## SOFTWARE

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### **TSCSMethods.jl** (sole author)

- Performs nonparametric generalized difference-in-differences estimation, with covariate matching

### **FormulaCompiler.jl** (sole author)

- Provides a unified, typed compilation framework for statistical model formulas in Julia

### **Margins.jl** (sole author)

- Computes marginal effects for generalized linear models and mixed models

### **SamplingPerceivedNetworks.jl** (sole author)

- Implements a sampling procedure for “cognitive social structures” data collection

## OTHER WRITING

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“Social network cognition among isolated villagers reveals distinct patterns of bias”. *Nature Human Behaviour Research Briefing* (June 2025). (Invited contribution by Nature Human Behaviour)

**Eric Feltham** and Nicholas Christakis. “Rapid research with a pandemic bearing down: Studying the impact of mass gatherings on the course of COVID-19”. *Springer Nature Communities* (2023). (Invited contribution to “Behind the Paper” series for the Springer Nature Social Sciences online community)

**Eric Feltham** and Nicholas Christakis. “Voting In The 2020 Primaries Didn’t Worsen The COVID-19 Pandemic”. *FiveThirtyEight* (2020).

## TEACHING

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**Teaching Fellow**, Yale College, Yale University (2018–2023):

- SOCY 133a, Computers, Networks and Society (Fall 2018)
- SOCY 167b, Social Networks and Society (Spring 2019)
- SOCY 151a, Foundations of Modern Social Theory (Fall 2019)
- SOCY 126b, Health of the Public (Spring 2020)
- SOCY 134a, Sex and Gender in Society (Fall 2021)
- SOCY 152b, Topics in Contemporary Social Theory (Spring 2022)
- SOCY 126a, Health of the Public (Fall 2022)
- SOCY 141b, Sociology of Crime and Deviance (Spring 2023)

## MENTORING

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- Ashley Oaks (Statistics & Data Science, Yale University, PhD)
- Shriya Muthukumar (Computer Science & Economics, University of Chicago, 2029)
- Aslı Yüksel (Psychology, Swarthmore College, 2026)
- Karen Gao (Computer Science & Psychology, Yale College, 2027)
- Breanna Nguyen (Cognitive Science, Yale College, 2025)
- Kaity Chandrika (Sociology, Yale College, 2025)
- Justice Harasha (Economics & Mathematics, Yale College, 2024)
- Kayla Morgan (Cognitive Science, Yale College, 2024)
- Benjamin Snyder (Economics, Yale College, 2022)

## RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

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### **Graduate Researcher**

**2016–2023**

Yale Institute for Network Science and Human Nature Lab, New Haven, CT

- Designed and led large-scale data collection and analysis efforts on individuals’ perceptions of social network structure with over 10,000 people in 82 villages in rural Honduras
- Developed sampling method for cognitive social structures research design
- Conducted fieldwork in rural Honduras to support data collection and analysis effort for thesis project
- Developed generalized difference-in-differences methodology to estimate the impact of large-scale political gatherings on the spread of COVID-19 in the USA

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| <b>Research Fellow</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | <b>2019</b>      |
| Dr. Emily Erikson, Yale University, New Haven, CT                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                  |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Analyzed historical social network data consisting of English economic manuscript writers from the 18th century</li> <li>Applied topic modeling to uncover trends in the economic literature over a roughly 200-year period</li> </ul> |                  |
| <b>Graduate Researcher</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <b>2018</b>      |
| University of Chicago, Chicago, IL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                  |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Part of a team on the grant “Social MIND: Social Machine Intelligence for Novel Discovery”, with Drs. James Evans and Michael Franklin of the University of Chicago and Dr. Joshua Tenenbaum of MIT</li> </ul>                         |                  |
| <b>Research Assistant (fMRI and fear conditioning)</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | <b>2014–2016</b> |
| Levy and Harpaz-Rotem Labs, Yale School of Medicine, New Haven, CT                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                  |
| <b>Research Assistant (human fear conditioning)</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>2014</b>      |
| Schiller Affective Neuroscience Lab, Icahn School of Medicine at Mount Sinai, New York, NY                                                                                                                                                                                    |                  |

## PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

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**Memberships.** American Sociological Association; International Network for Social Network Analysis  
**Ad hoc reviews.** Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences of the United States of America; PNAS Nexus; Sociological Science; Risk Analysis; Policy Analysis; Group Processes & Intergroup Relations; Rationality and Society; Yale Undergraduate Research Journal

## SKILLS

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**Programming.** Julia, R, MATLAB, Python. **Languages.** Spanish (basic), French (basic)

## LEADERSHIP & SERVICE

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| <b>Campaign Coordinator</b>                                                                                                     | <b>2010–2011</b> |
| Students for a Just and Stable Future, Boston, MA                                                                               |                  |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Built a statewide student climate coalition; contributed to MA climate policy</li> </ul> |                  |
| <b>Team Leader</b>                                                                                                              | <b>2010–2011</b> |
| Better Future Project, Boston, MA                                                                                               |                  |

## REFERENCES

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1. Dr. Peter Bearman, Jonathan R. Cole Professor of the Social Sciences, Columbia University (psb17@columbia.edu)
2. Dr. Nicholas Christakis, Sterling Professor of Social and Natural Science, Yale University (nicholas.christakis@yale.edu)
3. Dr. Emily Erikson, Professor of Sociology and (by courtesy) Management, Yale University (emily.erikson@yale.edu)
4. Dr. Laura Forastiere, Associate Professor of Biostatistics, Yale School of Public Health, Yale University (laura.forastiere@yale.edu)
5. Dr. Ifat Levy, Elizabeth Mears and House Jameson Professor of Comparative Medicine, with secondary appointments in Psychology and in Neuroscience, Yale School of Medicine, Yale University (ifat.levy@yale.edu)